Last Minute Courier - Game Script

Development version v0.5.2, November 4, 2026. Rules and core mechanics describe implemented behavior. Structure checked against lecture deck 3: slides 19-23 distinguish gameplay modes and shell screens; slide 55 asks for a non-technical rules script. Player timing and response remain measured acceptance tasks.

Background and goal

A campus film screening is about to begin. The courier carries the three things that make the evening possible: coffee for the audience, a lens for the projector, and the reel for the clocktower screening. A pocket device borrows seconds from marked machinery while the rest of the world keeps moving. The goal is to complete all three deliveries and open the cinema.

Learning goals

Learn moving and looking; physically jump over a low obstacle; recognize blue clock tags and keep Q held while crossing a moving cart lane. Then transfer the same time-control ability to boarding/riding lifts and judging a horizontal shuttle crossing. Alternative arcades and ramps let the player trade route length for precision. No new input is introduced during a timed delivery.

Rules and modes

Four untimed opening cards explain identity, ability, the delivery plan and controls. A practice yard teaches the three actions. WASD moves, mouse looks, Space jumps, Q slows marked devices, E interacts, C recenters, H opens help, Esc pauses, and R restarts the current unfinished order.

At each desk, E opens a brief. The player reads the parcel, destination and budget, then presses Enter to accept; Back cancels. Only acceptance starts the order clock. Orders have 140, 170 and 200 seconds. Q grants at most 3 seconds at 0.25 device speed, followed by 4 seconds of recharge. The courier and order clock do not slow. Pausing freezes gameplay; releasing Q while paused is resolved on resume.

A cart collision or fall returns the courier to a grounded checkpoint with a 0.3-second recovery fade and short collision immunity. The current order remains active. Timeout offers retry and route help. R restarts only the unfinished order, its devices and ability; earlier deliveries and stamps remain. Delivered and final states cannot be undone by R. Play Again starts a fresh run.

Scene and interaction sequence

1. Read the four cards, select an optional language, and practice in a safe yard with no delivery clock.

2. Accept coffee at the parcel desk. Cross cart traffic or use the arcade; jump or steer around planters. E delivers at the coffee stand and its warm light turns on.

3. Read and accept the lens at the same stand. Turn into the garden, use or bypass the first lift, cross the raised beds and stepping stones (or use the side route), then reach the projection booth via the second lift or ramp. The projector appears after delivery.

4. Read and accept the reel at the booth. Navigate traffic, ride or bypass a horizontal shuttle, ascend to the upper walk and negotiate planters. Follow the central cinema aisle, then turn left toward the roofless

clocktower console and its orange square. The screening lights and landscape screen reveal; a cinema ticket shows three stamps and the run statistics.

Feedback and presentation

Cream paper panels, ink text, orange route markings and teal clock tags establish distinct roles. The HUD identifies the current parcel, destination, distance/direction, clock and Q charge. Failed actions have explicit messages and recovery. Each completed delivery changes the world, plays a stamp cue and preserves progress. Warm sunset, stationary soft clouds and distant hills support orientation. A 48-second original musical base gains synchronized strings after coffee and bells after the lens; all three layers and interaction sounds share the sound switch. English is the startup language; six optional languages are selected from one menu.

Comfort and accessibility

Adjust field of view and sensitivity; optionally lock camera direction; use C to aim toward the route. No camera shake, head bob, motion blur or automatic speed zoom. Reading never consumes the order budget. Pausing suspends play, retries preserve earlier work, and route alternatives reduce dependence on precise platform timing. Keyboard menu navigation is supported. Comfort, readability and full mouse interaction still require player verification.

Iteration and evidence

The user requested a stronger opening, less generic typography, a prettier sky, enjoyable sounds and a comfortable 3D view. Technical checks also found tutorial bypasses, invalid-height interactions, ramp lips, misleading side-route navigation, default-grid terrain and an unbuilt-lighting warning. Implementations and observed regressions are recorded in ITERATIONS.md and QA-Evidence.json. These are development checks; genuine first-time player feedback and measured 5-10 minute pacing remain required.

v0.5 moment-to-moment clarity

In practice, wait for a gap, then keep Q held while walking from the near edge to the far edge of the blue lane. Release Q after clearing the lane. A short tap followed by an unslowed crossing repeats this untimed lesson from its approach. A completed slow crossing remains valid after releasing Q. During later deliveries, choose when to use the same ability. At a lift, wait for it to come down without spending Q, then hold Q and press Space to jump aboard. Once aboard, release Q so it carries you normally. At the far landing, walk forward to step off. Contextual prompts follow these stages and remain visible while Q is active. A nearby delivery desk shows ARRIVED and E Deliver package. Reading the next brief has no timer; only Accept delivery starts it.

Coffee delivery places hot cups on the counter and starts the strings. The second delivery brings the audience into the terrace and starts the bells. The last delivery reveals the moonlit screen, three-stamp ticket and wider concluding view. These are implemented feedback; their emotional impact requires player observation.

Player, perspective and competition

The expected player uses a keyboard and mouse and may be unfamiliar with timing challenges or 3D camera control. The player controls one courier from a following third-person camera, with an avatar-based interaction model. The intended skills are observation, coordinated movement, landing judgment and deciding when to spend a short time-control window. There is one local single-player campaign. There are no opponents, multiplayer rules, leaderboards, difficulty levels or separate time-trial mode. Improving one's own delivery time is an optional personal goal, not another implemented mode.

Complete mode and transition reference

Mode or shell screen	Available decisions and actions	Clock and devices	Exit
Opening shell	Four story/control cards; continue/back; language; quit	No delivery timer; devices inactive	Continue after card four enters practice
Practice gameplay	Move, look, jump, hold/release Q, C, pause/help	No delivery deadline; active training devices	Actual jump and Q held across the training lane, then reach parcel desk
Await-pickup gameplay	Walk to current desk; E reads brief; pause/help	No delivery deadline; delivery devices inactive	E at reachable desk enters briefing
Briefing shell	Read parcel, destination, route and budget; Enter accepts; Back cancels	No budget consumed	Accept enters delivery; cancel returns to pickup
Delivery gameplay (primary)	Move/look/jump/Q; E delivers; C; help/pause; R retries current order	Current budget and marked devices advance in real time, with selective Q slowdown	Valid E delivery, timeout, or pause
Pause/help shell	Resume; story/route help; sound, camera and language settings; retry when available; quit	Clock, devices, charge and recovery are frozen	Resume returns to the exact preceding gameplay state
Delivered shell	View outcome/stamp; read next brief; language	Completed delivery fixed; next timer has not started	Read next opens next brief at the same counter
Timeout shell	Retry unfinished order; view route help; language	No ongoing delivery or device movement	Retry returns to that order's pickup
Completion shell	Read ticket and statistics; language; Play Again	Three deliveries complete; ending animation plays	Play Again returns to opening and resets progress

Practice and delivery share the same avatar, camera and action vocabulary. Shell screens restrict world actions so reading and settings do not accidentally move the courier. Menu Tab selects controls; Space activates a focused toggle; Enter continues or accepts; sliders use Enter and arrows. A language change does not restart the order. Progress is session-only: quitting does not save a campaign. Play Again preserves selected presentation preferences in the current process; a fresh launch defaults to English.

Operational rules and edge cases

• Move relative to camera direction. Space jumps from the ground; holding it does not provide flight. Orange markers identify routes/interaction areas; blue clock tags identify devices affected by Q. A physical alternative route does not require a separate unlock.

• Q affects active blue carts and platforms, not the courier, scenery or order deadline. A full use has a maximum three-second allowance. Releasing early ends the effect and still starts a four-second recharge; unused allowance is not banked across recharge. At the end of recharge the full allowance returns. Holding through exhaustion does not automatically start another use: release and press again.

• On a moving platform, wait for it to reach the near landing, slow it if needed while boarding, release Q to travel at normal speed, and leave at the far landing. Holding Q throughout the ride makes travel slower. The longer side route trades travel time for easier geometry.

• E only reads or delivers within the marked area at a compatible height; standing underneath or far above a desk is invalid. An invalid E does not lose a parcel or advance an order. A reachable destination says ARRIVED and shows the delivery action.

• Coffee, lens and reel must be completed in that order. Accepting gives 140, 170 and 200 seconds respectively. Reading a brief never starts its clock. Delivery succeeds when E is used at the destination before the order reaches zero. An expired order must be retried.

• A fall, leaving the playable route or cart contact returns the courier to a safe grounded checkpoint. No stamp or parcel is removed. A brief recovery fade and collision protection prevent an immediate repeated hit. Timers and devices pause during the brief recovery itself; otherwise the order continues. Side-route landings also save checkpoints. Guidance moves back with the courier after recovery.

• R and the Retry control reset the current unfinished order to its pickup, including its deadline, device positions and Q allowance. Earlier completed orders, stamps, cups, audience and music progression remain. Retry is unavailable during untimed practice and does not undo delivered or completed states.

• The ending's delivery time is the sum of the three successful-order clocks. It excludes story reading, practice, pause, brief recovery and discarded attempts. The Retry counter counts explicit order restarts, not individual falls/cart recoveries. Neither statistic is a complete first-time wall-clock duration.

• There is no life limit, combat, inventory puzzle, hidden score threshold, random failure roll, currency, paid unlock or permanently lost progress within a running session. No special ending requires a fast time.

Ability teaching and later use

Ability	Initial demonstrated use	Later available transfer	Validation still needed
Move/look	Reach the practice marker with camera-relative WASD; recenter and mouse controls explained	Choose long arcades or short device routes, turn between landings and align with the final cinema aisle	First-time route comprehension without coaching
Jump	Actually jump over the low training step; simply walking around does not pass	Jump across stepping stones and onto or off a changing-height service platform; combine movement and landing judgment	A first-time player must demonstrate a later application; safe routes can bypass these challenges
Selective time control	Keep Q held from the near edge to the far edge of the blue training lane	Slow a lift/shuttle for boarding, release it to travel, then judge disembarkation; combine timing with movement and jumping	Platform physics regression passes; ordinary simultaneous Q + movement input and independent human learning transfer still require testing

The level provides later applications of every taught ability, but the optional bypasses mean completion alone does not prove all applications were used. For the highest rubric band, observe a first-time player recognizing and executing these transfers. If they always bypass them or fail to understand them, change route incentives and instruction placement and test again; do not report the criterion as complete merely because the objects exist.

Feedback-driven changes in v0.5.1

During ordinary keyboard play, the coffee awning crossed the camera on exit, decorative continuous curbs resembled roadblocks at merges, and garden recovery sent the courier back beyond the side ramp while guidance stayed ahead. The awning was shortened, curb/rail spans now leave supported intersections open, and safe side landings save progress while recovery rewinds guidance. A fresh ordinary-input run then completed all three orders without changing player position or state through a fixture. It included recoveries and pauses, optional camera lock, and read-only position/time logging; it is an agent technical run, not first-time human feedback.

A post-run German check exposed awkward stamp-word wrapping. Stamp spacing/type and separate delivery-time/retry lines were adjusted. Pause transitions now clear held-key state and pending movement so the courier does not resume stale input. Detailed evidence and local commits are indexed in ITERATIONS.md and QA-Evidence.json. Changes must be pushed to the required repository before submission; a local history or bundle is not a GitHub submission.

Feedback-driven changes in v0.5.2

Review of the standalone practice found that tapping Q briefly before walking through at full device speed still passed. Practice now checks Q staying active across the lane, with explicit release and recharge guidance. Lift hints explain waiting for a low platform, using Space to board, releasing Q during travel, and walking off at the landing. Active slowdown no longer masks the boarding prompt. Three engine regression suites pass with zero test errors or warnings, including early release, side bypass, recovery and context transitions. These controlled checks do not replace normal simultaneous keyboard input or a first-time human playtest.

Graduate Mechanics and Balance Analysis

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Required for this student's graduate submission. Based on lecture deck 4, The Art of Game Design: mechanics 1-7 and the balance lenses on slides 104, 112 and 118. The following answers refer to implemented rules. Statements about player feelings are hypotheses until genuine player observation is recorded.

Seven mechanic categories

Course mechanic	Implemented model and example	What the player decides
1. Space	A continuous, bounded 3D campus with ground, raised landings, ramps, gaps and connected routes. Desks and delivery zones are meaningful subspaces. Height matters: E from beneath a desk is invalid.	Choose a connected route, align with a landing, and reach the correct interaction area.
2. Time	Continuous movement; separate 140/170/200-second order clocks; Q slows active blue-tagged machinery to 0.25 speed for up to three real seconds, followed by four seconds of recharge. Reading is untimed; pause suspends simulation.	Spend the window after observing a gap; release Q after boarding; balance longer safe travel against a deadline.
3. Objects, attributes and states	Courier: position, grounded/jumping/recovering, held parcel. Cart: lane position and time phase. Platform: location and boarding/riding state. Order: unread, accepted, delivered or expired. Borrower: ready, active or recharging. Desks, stamps and the cinema have persistent delivered states within a run.	Read visible cart/platform motion, charge bar, delivery count and clock to choose the next action.
4. Actions	Basic actions: move, look, jump, hold/release Q and interact. Strategic actions: wait for a gap, preserve a charge for boarding, release it during travel, choose a bypass, or retry an order after learning its route.	Combine a small set of verbs in different sequences. Settings and help are shell actions, not additional courier powers.
5. Rules	Three ordered parcels, reachable-height interaction, limited Q use, grounded checkpoints, order-specific timeouts and retries, and a three-delivery completion condition. The game enforces these rules; the script states their consequences.	Complete the current goal within its budget, recover from a mistake, and understand which progress persists.
6. Skill	Physical: coordinate camera-relative movement, jumping and landings. Mental: observe periodic machinery, estimate a safe interval and compare routes. No social opponent or avatar-stat upgrade system is required.	Improve real observation and coordination through practice rather than buying numerical power.
7. Chance	Gameplay-critical traffic and platform movement are periodic, not random success rolls. Arrival timing can feel uncertain to a novice; motion can be observed and learned. Cosmetic variation does not decide whether a delivery succeeds.	Take an informed timing risk or choose a longer route; failure is not assigned by a dice roll.

These categories describe different aspects of the same interaction. For example, slowing a lift combines time, a platform's changing attributes, player action, limited-charge rules, 3D landing space and player skill. Its success is not a random probability check.

Balance lens 1: Reward (deck 4, slide 104)

1. What rewards exist, and what other forms are possible? Each successful delivery gives a visible stamp, an explicit delivery result, a short sound and a persistent world change. Coffee adds cups/steam and strings; the lens prepares the projector, audience and bells; the reel reveals the screen and combines the stamps into a cinema ticket. These are implemented. A numerical score or cosmetic shop is not implemented and is not needed for the current cooperative story.

2. Are rewards exciting or boring, and why? The design hypothesis is that an inhabited scene and a seat at the event make the task feel consequential. An agent can verify that objects, result text and music-layer state change; it cannot establish excitement. Ask first-time players what changed after each delivery and which moment they cared about, recording contrary responses as well.

3. Do players understand the reward? A completion count, named parcel stamp, written outcome and changed destination communicate the same event through several channels. The final card explains that three stamps form one admission ticket. Comprehension remains a playtest criterion: the tester should explain why the ticket appears without coaching.

4. Is the reward too regular, and should timing vary? Three major rewards are deliberately predictable because there are exactly three concrete deliveries. Their intervals and presentation differ with the route and parcel. Random reward schedules would obscure the causal link between helping and the scene changing. Whether a route's interval feels too long must be measured, not assumed.

5. How are rewards connected? They are preparation for one film night: audience comfort, projection capability and film content. The same delivery stamps become the final ticket, and musical layers accumulate rather than replacing unrelated tracks. This connection is part of both the implemented world and the opening story.

6. Does the reward build too quickly or slowly? The sequence grows from a local coffee response to a populated terrace and then the screening. The agent's full run has 4:07 of successful-order clock time, excluding reading, practice and pause; this is insufficient to establish reward pacing for first-time humans. Record each delivery's wall time and response before changing route length or adding rewards.

Balance lens 2: Punishment (deck 4, slide 112)

1. What punishments exist? Cart contact or falling causes a short setback to a grounded checkpoint. Timeout requires retrying the unfinished order. An explicit retry discards that order's attempt, restores its clock and resets its devices/charge. Earlier parcels and world changes survive. There is no finite life pool, harsh score penalty or full-campaign reset after one error.

2. Why punish, and what should it achieve? A visible setback gives traffic timing and safe landings a consequence. Retrying a single order gives the player a chance to apply newly learned timing without replaying already mastered routes. The purpose is attention and learning, not humiliation or lengthening play through repeated work.

3. Does the punishment feel fair, and why or why not? The design uses visible machinery, clear failure messages, a brief recovery fade and collision immunity. Native garden play showed that the old checkpoint was too far back and guidance stayed ahead after recovery. v0.5.1 saves the side-ramp landing and rewinds route guidance; engine regression and a fresh input run verified this change. Perceived fairness still needs players' reports; repeated unanticipated recoveries would count against it.

4. Could a reward produce the same or better effect? Safe progress is already rewarded by new checkpoints and preserved delivery stamps. The game avoids subtracting delivered stamps or adding an arbitrary time penalty. A cleaner crossing naturally leaves more deadline time, without an extra score system. Removing every setback would make machinery less meaningful; the current compromise keeps the local challenge and limits repeated work.

5. Are strong penalties matched by strong rewards? The strongest current setback is replaying one order, not the whole campaign. Its reward is a persistent contribution to the screening, with the final parcel opening the event. Whether the order budgets and repetition are proportionate is a first-time test question. Do not justify a frustrating timeout solely by saying the ending is a reward.

Balance lens 3: Simplicity and complexity (deck 4, slide 118)

1. What innate complexity exists? Players must know the blue-tag rule, three-second allowance, four-second recharge, the difference between reading and accepting, the delivery order and the difference between checkpoint recovery and retry. These rules are explained in cards, practice, contextual hints, the brief and pause help. Seven language options share the same rules.

2. Can innate complexity become emergent complexity? One Q rule is used on carts, vertical lifts and a horizontal shuttle. There is no separate freeze power, vehicle control scheme or per-device recharge rule. Observing and combining that one rule with movement creates the later decisions. Directly opening the next untimed brief removes an unnecessary extra interaction.

3. What emergent interactions arise? Slowing a cart extends a crossing window but still spends real order time; slowing a lift helps boarding but delays travel if held; a longer ramp avoids precision but costs travel time. Releasing Q can therefore be strategically useful. These interactions are implemented; whether novices independently discover them must be observed.

4. Is anything too simple? If players always choose bypasses, they may finish without transferring Q or jumping to a new context. The full agent run verifies those accessible routes, not learning transfer. The v0.5.2 tutorial now checks a crossing while Q stays held, and the lift prompts explicitly cover waiting, jumping aboard, releasing Q and stepping off. The next genuine playtest must record route choices and later ability use. If transfer is absent, revise the first lift's instruction/route incentive and retest before claiming the rubric's highest mechanics band. Do not add a hidden gate or unrelated busywork merely to force longer play.

Evidence and submission relationship

GameScript.md states the complete player-facing rules and modes. ITERATIONS.md and QA-Evidence.json distinguish ordinary-input checks, controlled physics tests and actual human feedback. Human playtests are currently zero. This analysis does not convert a design hypothesis into a tested finding; the final report must add observed player evidence and the corresponding revision commits.